

But for how long will these consoles stay before giving way to virtual reality (VR) consoles? The consoles of the future may be able to combine a number of technologies including display, sound and force feedback. Hardware and game developers could



Virtual Reality is no longer restricted to sci-fi films

take a cue from sci-fi films, where VR systems were used for recreation, relaxation and simulation combat.

With simulating techniques already being developed and advances in VR happening, the days of being in the middle of the battlefield does not seem to be far off. Controllers for games would also be futuristic—a simple joystick or controller pad just won't do. You would instead be saddled with a gun if you're engaging in combat, or perhaps a light sabre if you're cool enough to handle it. A headset or a 3D display unit would be *de rigueur*. In addition to these, to simulate the seismic shakeouts during a crash or a volcanic eruption, you might even have special boots strapped to your feet—or even a special floor pad. Sensors would be attached to your body to mimic your movements in the virtual world.

Such devices aren't as far off in the future as you might think. Take the case of a system called 'Trimersion', which was showcased at the E3 games exhibition of 2005. The 'device' promises 360-degree head tracking for home gaming. It uses a binocular video system that delivers QVGA resolution (320 x 240). According to Kopin, the manufacturer of the video system, this is the virtual equivalent of a 35-inch display viewed from a distance of seven feet.

The VR platform promises gamers the ability to control key ele-